Joe Egg

By Peter Nichols

BRI: Sheila's got a theory about Joe's birth. She doesn't blame the doctors. She blames herself.

SHEILA: I don't say that. I say it wasn't entirely the doctors.

BRI: Because she'd slept around

SHEILA: I think it was partly because I'd been promiscuous, yes, and my subconscious was making me shrink or withdraw from motherhood, all right!

BRI: That vicar told us it was the devil's doing. Why don't you believe that? It's about as brilliant.

SHEILA: (shrugs) It comes down in the end to what you believe.

BRI: I'll tell you what I believe.

SHEILA: I know what you believe.

BRI: (points at audience) They don't. (To audience) I believe the doctor botched it. There was no other cause. (To Sheila) That specialist said as much, he said it had nothing at all to do with the way you'd lived or whether there was a nut in the family . . . or what kind of [cigarettes] you smoked. . .

SHEILA: He didn't say the doctor did it either.

BRI: No. You've got a good point there. He didn't mention that, quite true. He didn't say, "Yes, he's a shoddy midwife, my colleague, always was, I'll see he gets struck off the register." Very true Weakens my argument. That.

SHEILA: Oh, you're so clever!

BRI: He'd only say for certain that it was a chance in a million it could happen again . . . It's due to this that Joe lives at home with us.

SHEILA: She's our daughter.

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BRI: (to audience) She was on the way before we married. That feeds the furnace of guilt.

SHEILA: No need to tell them everything. (to audience) But she's no trouble. It's Brian. I don't know which is the greatest baby. Watching somebody as limited as Joe over ten years, I've begun to feel she's only one kind of cripple. Everybody's damaged in some way. There's a limit to what we can do. Brian, for instance, he goes so far – and hits the ceiling. Just can't fly any higher. Then he drops to the floor and we get self-pity again . . . despair.

INTRODUCTION

How do parents come to terms with their daughter's persistent vegetative state? At first, it seems that they deal with the situation by laughing about it. However, after nearly 10 years, Bri has given up hope for his daughter and believes that her death would be a release. His wife, Sheila, believes that she will one day recover. Bri's humor is indeed his way of dealing with the trauma. But Sheila's laughter is an attempt to keep Bri happy and the marriage together. The characters of Bri and Sheila represent opposite sides of the moral argument on such cases: Do we have the right to decide whether a human being should live or die or is it cruel to artificially prolong a life that consists only of severe fits and constant pain?

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BRI: (To audience) How long do your labours last? Two, three hours? A day? Dilettantes! (Points a Sheila) Five days!

SHEILA: (To audience) This doctor kept on drugging me. (To Bri) You never thought it was going on too long?

BRI: Yes, but you leave it to them, don't you? My mum taught me to believe in doctors.

SHEILA: The next I knew, they handed me this hairless yellow baby with forceps-scars all over her scalp. She was gorgeous. . . . But soon I began to notice these funny turns. We took her to our new G.P.

(Sheila mimes holding a baby)

BRI: Baby. (Indicates mimed baby). (Points to himself) Doctor. What seems to be the trouble.

SHEILA: I don't really know. Funny turns. Face-making. Blinking with her eyes, working with her tongue, shaking her head, then going all limp.

BRI: (tickling the baby and talking to it) Funny turns indeed at your age! Saucy beggar. We are not amused.

SHEILA: But what d'you think it is?

BRI: Gas. Have you tried Gripe Water? Let's see what we can find in here. (Rummages in drawer, finds medicine, reads label). Ah, yes, this'll put a stop to it.

SHEILA: Doctor – I wish you could see one of these turns.

BRI: Oh, I've seen them, dear. Got three of my own. Your first, is it? First baby?

SHEILA: Yes.

BRI: Well, dear, it's like this. Take it easy, give 'em a chance. (Tickles the baby, looks again at medicine). Let's see. Three times daily after meals. I've got a waiting-room full of people, dear. You try her with this and come back if there's no improvement in – say – a week. And don't fret, Bye-bye. . . .

Three days later

SHEILA: (urgently) Doctor –

BRI: Didn't I say come back in a week? Why so soon?

SHEILA: She's gone into a coma. She won't take anything. She hasn't fed for two days.

BRI: (Looks at baby, listens to it, claps hands by it, finally shakes it like a piggy-bank – goes humming back to the table, mimes dialing) Get me the Children's Hospital . . . quick!

SHEILA: (turning to audience) I said to Brian, "I've got a feeling we shan't bring her back." But we did . . . eventually. I stayed in hospital with her for a few weeks, then left her there having tests. A few weeks later they called me to collect Joe from the hospital by which time we'd gathered that she wasn't ever going to amount

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to much. But I was determined to know the best we could expect. And the worst. The pediatrician was German.

(For this sketch, Bri uses a music-hall German accent)

BRI: Vell, mattam, zis baby off yours has now been soroughly test and ve need ze bets razzer battly so it's better you take her home. I sink I can promise she von't be any trouble. Keep her vell sedated you'll hartly know she's zere.

SHEILA: But, Doctor – can't you tell me the results of the tests?

BRI: Vitch ones? Zere vere so many – (slight laugh. Lists on fingers) Electro-encephalopraph, scree-dimensional eggs-ray, blood urine and stool analyses, zis business vis needles in ze fontanelle –

SHEILA: Is that why her hair's been shaved off?

BRI: Vell of course –

SHEILA: She'd only just begun to grow it. And did the needles make that scar on her head?

BRI: Ach, nein. Zis vos a liddle biopsy to take a sample of her brain tissue.

SHEILA: That's a relief (She smiles quickly) I thought at first you bored a hole in her skull to let the devil out.

BRI: (Looks interested, confers with his assistant). Sounds gut. Did you try it? (To Sheila) My colleague says ve don't do zat any more. (Shrugs) Pity! Vell – if you eggscuse me. (Moves to go)

SHEILA: But – Doctor, Doctor – What can she do?

BRI: Do? She can't do nozzing at all.

SHEILA: Will she ever?

BRI: Mattam, let me try and tell you vot your daughter iss like. Do you know vot I mean ven I say your daughter vos a wegetable?

SHEILA: (Thinks for a moment, gets it, smiles) Yes! You mean "Your daughter was a vegetable."

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BRI: Ach himmel! Stil is, stil iss, always vill be! I have trouble vis Englisch werbs. Zere's von born every eight hours, you know.

SHEILA: No, I didn't. Is that true?

BRI: Oh, ja, ja. Not all as bas as zees case, of course –

SHEILA: Isn't there anything at all we can do?

BR: But jawohl! You must feed her, vosh her nappies, keep her varm. Just like any ozzer mozzer.

SHEILA: But for how long?

BRI: Who can tell? Anysing can happen. You know zat. Diphtheria, pneumonia . . . vooping cough. (Breaks character) So—what happened then? We brought her home.

SHEILA: And the hospital passed the can back to our local G.P. He had to supply phenobarbitone and keep us happy. But the time came when I asked him whose fault it was.

BRI: Which is when he suggested the vicar might call.

SHEILA: Yes. Nice vicar. Sensitive. So concerned and upset at the sight of Joe – the fits were unusually bad that day – so we left her in the cot and had our chat in another room.

BRI: She's a beautiful child. It's tragic. Tell me – when you first – knew there was nothing to be done, how did you feel?

SHEILA: Well, of course, you find out gradually, not all at once. But there is a point when you finally accept it. And that's – (shakes her head) Oh, very nasty. You think "why me?" I don't know about the other mothers but I kept saying, "Why me, why us?" all day long. Then you get tired of that and you say, "Why not me?"

BRI: Tell me, what was your husband's reaction to the child?

SHEILA: He used to say, "Think of something worse." And of course that's easy. Joe could have grown older and developed into a real person before it happened. Or she

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could have been a very intelligent spastic without the use of her limbs. Which is worse, I think, than being a kind of living parsnip.

BRI: Quote. You count your blessings . . . and that give you fortitude.

SHEILA: No, but it's something to do. When you're up against a – disaster of this kind – an Act of God – (Bri clears his throat) – it's so numbing you feel you msut make some sense of it –botherwise – you'd –

BRI: Give up hope?

SHEILA: Yes. My husband doesn't feel the need to make sense of anything. He lives with despair.

BRI: (coming out of character) Did you tell him that?

SHEILA: He says I shouldn't look for explanations.

BRI: He doesn't believe in God?

SHEILA: His own kind of God. A manic-depressive – He doesn't like me praying.

BRI: You've been praying?

SHEILA: What else can I do? I look at that flawless little body, those glorious eyes, and I pray for some miracle to – get her started. It seems, if we only knew the key or the combination, we could get her moving. D'you think the story of Sleeping Beauty was about a spastic? (breaks out of sketch) He was a good man, kind and sincere.

BRI: He was, yes.

SHEILA: (to audience) As soon as we were admitted to the free-masonry of spastics parents, we saw she had even less character than the other children. So we began to make them for her.

BRI: Some never really suited.

SHEILA: No. Like the concert pianist dying of t.b.

BRI: I used to like the drunken bag who threw bottles at us if we didn't fetch her gin and pip-tobacco.

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SHEILA: But they were all too active. The facial expression wasn't right. (Bri freezes – Sheila – to audience) I join in these jokes to please him. IF it helps him live the her, I can't see the ham, can you? He hasn't any faith she's ever going to improve. Where I have, you see . . . I believe, even if she showed improvement, Bri wouldn't notice. He's dense about faith – faith isn't believing in fairy-tales, its being in a receptive state of mind. I'm always on the look-out for some sign . . . . I think while there's life there's hope, don't you? I wish he'd talk more seriously about her. I wonder if he ever imagines what she'd be like if her brain worked. I do.

BRI: Our marriage might have worked as well as most if Joe hadn't happened. I was too young for it, that's true, of course. I always will be. But Sheila might just have dragged me screaming into manhood. 'Stead of which, I was one of the menagerie. She loved me as much as any goldfish or [plant]. So now it was a question of how to tell her I was leaving her. And when I went into it, I saw it wouldn't only be about Joe, but also about my ambitions . . . . so in the end I better just creep away without a word . . . (Begins hurriedly putting various objects into his pockets, putting on coat, etc) So I've shaved and washed and packed a case . . . (Gets case from hall, stands near by) haven't decided where I'm going yet.

SHEILA: I shall go on up. Will you carry Joe to her room when you come up? She's such a lump. (Bri nods, Sheila leaves, Bri picks up his case and goes).

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Peter Nichols

ISBN: 978-0802151155
Publisher: Grove Press, Inc
Date (Month/Year): June 1967

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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